offered would be sufficient for two weeks' wages at most. He added that the promised assistance would 'not provide any signal of commitment to our business or to our workforce, nor would it meaningfully provide help through the downturn or enable us to recover more strongly in the upturn'.

Some European countries like Germany, the Netherlands, France and Spain had embraced several initiatives to support companies during the time of crisis. These included subsidizing 'manpower costs to enable companies' to 'reduce production' without permanently cutting jobs. The UK government had 'no such initiative and no such scheme in place to support and sustain the steel industry, or for that matter, any other industry in the manufacturing sector'. And regrettably, that led to 'permanent job reductions in the UK' at 'great economic and social costs'. Ashok Kumar, the Middlesbrough South and East Cleveland MP who had at one time worked at Teesside, also intervened with the government. He wrote to Prime Minister Brown, but it yielded little. He too blamed the government, stating that its 'response is not enough'.

Ratan faced strong headwinds from all directions. Even amid the crisis, the British management was disinclined to change their work culture. Ratan reflected his disappointment in an interview with *The Times*, saying that in India 'if you are in a crisis, if it means working to midnight, you would do it'. He added that while the workers were 'willing to do that; the management' was not. He lamented that the 'entire engineering group would be empty on Friday evening'.

By December 2009, with barely any help from the government, some of the facilities at the Teesside plant were mothballed. In a press release the Tatas clarified, 'The decision to partially mothball TCP [Teesside] follows strenuous efforts by Corus over the past eight months to secure a long-term future for the plant', after the four international contractors mentioned earlier failed to fulfil their obligations.

In reply to a letter written by Sir John Rose, CEO of Rolls-Royce, in which he had also referred to the loss of jobs in the steel plants, Ratan lamented that he was 'sorry' to mothball the Teesside facility. He added that it was on account of the 'illegal withdrawal' of contracts and the 'apathy of the British government' to 'mitigate the resulting situation'. The government's lack of concern regarding this issue was as disconcerting as it was surprising.